Mike Zabek

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Position

Principal Economist, Federal Reserve Board, 2026–Present

Senior Economist, Federal Reserve Board, 2021–26

Economist, Federal Reserve Board, 2018–21

Education

Ph.D., Economics, University of Michigan, 2018

M.A., Economics, University of Michigan, 2013

B.A., Mathematics and Economics, Kenyon College (summa cum laude, Phi Beta Kappa), 2008

Peer-reviewed publications

"What makes a job better? Survey evidence from job changers" (with Katherine Lim)

Monthly Labor Review (June 2026).
FEDS Working Paper (2024)
Press: The Economist, Wall Street Journal, BLS Monthly Labor Review write-up

"Local Ties in Spatial Equilibrium"

American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics (April 2024) Volume 16, Number 2.
FEDS Working Paper (2019)

"Women's Labor Force Exits during COVID-19: Differences by Motherhood, Race, and Ethnicity" (with Katherine Lim)

Journal of Family and Economic Issues (September 2024) Volume 45, Issue 3.
FEDS Working Paper (2021)
Press: The Atlantic

"Parental Proximity and Earnings after Job Displacements" (with Pawel Krolikowski and Patrick Coate)

Labour Economics (August 2020) Volume 65, 101877.
FEDS Working Paper (2019); Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland Working Paper (2017)
Press: Wall Street Journal: Real Time Economics, Forbes, The Atlantic, MarketWatch

Working papers

"Effects of labor market tightness on job quality: Evidence from job changers" (with Brad Hershbein, Katherine Lim, and Douglas Webber)

Under revision
FEDS Working Paper (2026); CESifo Working Paper (2026)

"Personal Tax Changes and Financial Well-being: Effects of 2017 Tax Reform" (with Christine Dobridge and Joanne Hsu)

Submitted
FEDS Working Paper (2024); CESifo Working Paper (2025)

Work in progress

"Housing inequality across neighborhoods" (with Aditya Aladangady; draft expected soon)

Policy publications

"Shedding Light on Survey Accuracy: A Comparison between SHED and Census Bureau Survey Results" (2025) with Kabir Dasgupta and Fatimah Shaalan. Finance and Economics Discussion Series 2025-010.

"Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2024" (2025) with Alicia Lloro, Ellen Merry, Jeff Larrimore, Zofsha Merchant, Fatimah Shaalan, and Julie Siwicki.

"New data on non-compete contracts and what they mean for workers" (2023) with Tyler Boesch, Jacob Lockwood, and Ryan Nunn. Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis online article.

"Women of color and women with children disproportionately left the labor force during the COVID-19 pandemic" (2022) with Katherine Lim. Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis online article.

"Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2020" (2021) with Kenneth Brevoort, Sara Canilang, Kayla Jones, Jeff Larrimore, Alicia Lloro, Ellen Merry, Anna Tranfaglia, and Erin Troland.

"Household Finances Under COVID-19: Evidence from the Survey of Household Economics and Decisionmaking" (2020) with Jeff Larrimore. Consumer and Community Context, vol. 2, no. 2, pp. 2–8.

"Update on the Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households: July 2020 Results" (2020) with Sara Canilang, Kayla Jones, Jeff Larrimore, and Ellen Merry.

"Report on the Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2019, Featuring Supplemental Data from April 2020" (2020) with Sara Canilang, Cassandra Duchan, Kimberly Kreiss, Jeff Larrimore, Ellen Merry, and Erin Troland.

"Report on the Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2018" (2019) with Alex Durante, Lisa Chen, Cassandra Duchan, Kimberly Kreiss, Ellen Merry, Barbara Robles, and Claudia Sahm.

"Parental Assistance after Job Loss" (2018) with Patrick Coate and Pawel Krolikowski. Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland *Economic Commentary* 2018-07.

"Parental Proximity and the Earnings Consequences of Job Loss" (2017) with Patrick Coate and Pawel Krolikowski. Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland *Economic Commentary* 2017-03.

"The 2009 Survey of Consumer Payment Choice" (2011) with Kevin Foster, Erik Meijer, and Scott Schuh. Federal Reserve Bank of Boston *Public Policy Discussion Paper* 11-1.

"The 2008 Survey of Consumer Payment Choice" (2009) with Kevin Foster, Erik Meijer, and Scott Schuh. Federal Reserve Bank of Boston *Public Policy Discussion Paper* 09-10.

Resting papers

"Housing inequality" (with David Albouy)

NBER Working Paper 21916.

Press: Washington Post, Washington Center for Equitable Growth, The Atlantic: City Lab

Fellowships, Awards, and Honors

Federal Reserve Board, Division of Consumer and Community Affairs award for work on the Survey of Household Economics and Decisionmaking, 2026

Federal Reserve Board, Division of Consumer and Community Affairs Special award for policy work on the Community Reinvestment Act Modernization, 2023

Federal Reserve Board, Division of Consumer and Community Affairs Division and Spot awards for policy work, 2021

Federal Reserve Board, Division of Consumer and Community Affairs award for policy work on the COVID Pandemic, 2020

Finalist for HCEO and Upjohn Institute Dissertation Prizes, 2019

Rackham Predoctoral Fellowship, University of Michigan, 2017–18

University of Michigan Population Studies Center NICHD Predoctoral Fellowship, 2013–14, 15–16, 16–17

Parker Memorial Prize in Labor Economics, University of Michigan, 2016

Marshall Weinberg Research Fellowship, University of Michigan, 2015–16

University of Pennsylvania Social Science and Policy Forum Pre-dissertation Fellowship, 2013

University of Michigan Summer Research Assistantship, 2012 and 2013

University of Michigan SYLF Fellowship, 2011–12

Federal Reserve Bank of Boston Award, 2009

Phi Beta Kappa, Kenyon College, 2008

Presentations

2026: Society of Labor Economists, Western Economic Association International, Federal Reserve Board, University of California Berkeley Haas (scheduled).

2025: ASSA (joint with SGE), Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland, College Fed Challenge, APPAM.

2024: Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia, Society of Government Economists, LMU Munich, University of Richmond, Northeastern Regional Consumer Compliance Meetings.

2023: Federal Reserve Board, APPAM, ASSA (joint with SGE).

2022: Population Association of America, Society of Labor Economists, Federal Reserve Board Internal Diversity and Inclusion seminar.

2021: American Economic Association, Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich, Federal Reserve System Regional Meetings (discussant).

2020: University of Nebraska, Federal Reserve System Regional, Urban Economics Association, Southern Economic Association.

2019: Society of Labor Economists; Federal Reserve System Applied Micro (discussant); Georgetown Center for Economic Research; Urban Economics Association Annual Meetings; Federal Reserve System Regional.

2018: University of Delaware; the U.S. Naval Academy; German IAB Conference on Demographics, Immigration, and the Labor Market; Health, History, Demography, and Development Research Day at the University of Michigan; several potential employers.

2017: American Economic Association (joint with AREUEA); Health, History, Demography, and Development Research Day at Michigan; U.S. Census Bureau CES; Society of Labor Economists (poster); Barcelona GSE Summer Forum; IRP Summer Research Workshop at the University of Wisconsin; Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland; Cleveland State University; APPAM; Upjohn Institute.

2016: University of Michigan (Labor lunch, Macro lunch, H2D2 lunch, Summer seminar); Population Association of America; Midwest Economic Association; EconCon at Princeton; Urban Economics Association; Midwest Macro.

2015: University of Michigan (Public Finance lunch, Labor lunch, Macro lunch, Summer seminar, Health, History, Demography, and Development Research Day).

2014: University of Michigan (Labor lunch, Summer seminar).

2013: University of Pennsylvania SSPF Summer Institute.

Referee

Journals: *AEJ: Economic Policy (x3)*; *Journal of Urban Economics (x2)*; *Journal of the European Economic Association (x2)*; *International Economic Review (x2)*; *Journal of Political Economy*; *Review of Economics and Statistics*; *Journal of Labor Economics*; *AEJ: Applied*; *AEJ: Macroeconomics*; *Industrial Relations*; *Journal of Public Economics*; *Journal of Economic Geography*; *Journal of Human Resources*; *Regional Science and Urban Economics*; *Journal of the Association of Environmental and Resource Economists*; *Demographic Research*; *Journal of Public Economic Theory*; *Population Research and Policy Review*

Conferences: 2021 Federal Reserve Community Development Research Conference, Uneven Outcomes in the Labor Market: Understanding Trends and Identifying Solutions (2020 Atlanta Fed Conference), 2019 Annual Meeting of the American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association, 2018 Federal Reserve Community Development Research Conference

Grants: Fonds de la Recherche Scientifique (x2)

Teaching Experience

Statistics Project Mentor, Howard University

Financial Literacy/Data Analysis with R, five semesters over 2019–24

Graduate Student Instructor, University of Michigan Department of Economics

Honors Introductory Economics with William J. Adams, Winter 2015

Economics of the European Union with William J. Adams, Fall 2014

Introductory Microeconomics with Janet Gerson, Fall 2012

Previous Research Experience

Visiting Scholar, Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich, 2024

Graduate Student Research Assistant, Health and Retirement Study, 2013

Research Analyst, The Moving to Opportunity Project at the NBER, 2011

Research Associate, The Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL), 2010

Senior Research Assistant, Federal Reserve Bank of Boston, 2008–10

Miscellaneous

CESifo Research Fellow August 2024–Present

Languages: English (Native); French (Intermediate/B2); German (Basic/A1)

U.S. Citizen; Private Pilot, Single Engine Land

Steering committee/co-organizer: Federal Reserve and George Washington University Financial Literacy Seminar Series, 2018–19; Michigan Ph.D. Summer Seminar, Summers 2015, 2016, 2017

University of Pennsylvania Social Science and Policy Forum Summer Institute on Inequality, 2013

University of Chicago Summer School on Socioeconomic Inequality, 2013